The Myth of British Politeness

Target Audience: B1+ / B2 (Upper-Intermediate)
Time: 45-50 minutes
Approach: CLIL + Socio-cultural approach (Safonova's "Dialogue of Cultures")
Methodological Framework: TBL (Task-Based Learning) with elements of Guided Discovery.

Lesson Objectives:

- Educational (Content): Students will understand the concept of "polite-isms" in British English and the cultural value of "not imposing".
- Linguistic (Language): Students will practice vocabulary related to communication (e.g., *stereotype, confrontation, polite-ism, to impose, misunderstanding*), and develop reading and speaking skills.
- Socio-cultural (Safonova's approach): Students will develop cultural sensitivity, learn to decode hidden meanings in British speech, and compare British communication styles with their own culture (Dialogue of Cultures).

Stage	Stage aim	Timing	Procedure	Aids and materials
Warm-up	Activate background knowledge and introduce the core cultural conflict.	5 min	Task 1: The "Direct vs Indirect" question.Teacher asks: *"If you want someone to move out of your way, what do you say?"*(Students usually say "Move", "Excuse me"). Task 2: The Problem Scenario. Teacher says: *"A British person says: 'Oooh, could I just squeeze past you?' What do they REALLY mean?"* Students brainstorm in pairs.	Map or picture of a crowded London Tube.
Controlled Practice	To present the target vocabulary and provide controlled	7 min	Task 1: Vocabulary Match. Students match words with definitions: *stereotype,*	Vocabulary Match, presentation

	practice to check understanding.		*confrontation, polite-ism, to impose*. Task 2: Prediction. Students look at the title *"The Myth of British Politeness"* and guess if the text will say British people are actually polite or not.	slide
Pre-Reading	Set the purpose for reading the text.	3 min	Teacher asks: *"We know they say 'sorry' a lot. But is it real politeness or just a code? Let's read to find out."* Students have 1 minute to skim the text and find the main idea.	Presentation slide, text Terribly sorry – but Britain's famed politeness may be a myth | Lynne Murphy | The Guardian , New research explores British 'Polite-isms' and their impact on communication
Reading	Develop reading skills for detailed understanding of British communication style.	10 min	Students read the text carefully and complete the table: *What a British person says vs. What they actually mean.* Then they answer the comprehension questions.	Text, slide, task, table
Post-Reading (Freer Practice)	Apply knowledge, develop critical thinking through the "Dialogue of Cultures"	15 min	Task 1: Role-Play "Cultural Translator".Group work. Students are given 3 direct situations (e.g., "You hate the food"). They must write how a British person would say it politely, and how a person from their own country would say it. Task 2: Dialogue of Cultures. Discuss: *"Is it better to be direct (like in our culture) or indirect (like in the UK)? What are the*	Translator template, board for comparison.

			pros and cons of both?"	
Homework and feedback	Summarize, consolidate, and reflect on cultural importance.	5 min	Reflection: *"Why is it dangerous to interpret another culture's words literally?"* Homework: Write a short guide for a foreigner coming to your country. Explain 3 phrases that mean something different in your culture.	Board, students' notebooks.

Vocabulary Match

Task 2: Match the words (1-4) with their definitions (A-D). Write the correct letter in the box.

Word	Letter	Definition
1. Stereotype	[ ]	A. A phrase that sounds polite but actually means something else (often the opposite).
2. Confrontation	[ ]	B. A fixed idea about a group of people that may not be true.
3. Polite-ism	[ ]	C. To force your presence or opinions on someone in an annoying way (to make them uncomfortable).
4. To impose	[ ]	D. A situation where people argue or fight because they have different opinions.

Answers: 1- B, 2- D, 3- A, 4- C

The Myth of British Politeness
(Adapted from Trinity College London & The Guardian)

Everyone knows that British people are extremely polite. They say "sorry" when someone bumps into them, they queue quietly, and they never complain. But is this stereotype actually true?

According to a recent survey by Trinity College London, the British really do hate confrontation. 83% of people in the UK said they avoid arguments at all costs. In fact, Britons use an average of 14 polite-isms per day. These are phrases that sound polite but actually mean something else. For example, if a British person says *"Oooh, could I just squeeze past you?"*, they really mean "Get out of my way". If they say *"Sounds fun, I'll let you know"*, it actually means "I'm not coming".

So, why are they like this? Some experts say it's because British culture values "not imposing" on other people. They want to avoid making others feel uncomfortable. But this can be confusing for foreigners. When a British person says *"I'll think about it"* or *"We must have lunch sometime"*, they might just be being polite, not making a real plan.

Of course, not all British people are the same. Manners can change depending on the situation, the region, or the generation. But understanding this "polite code" is an important step in understanding British culture.

Task 3.1: Read the text and complete the table.
What does a British person say, and what do they REALLY mean?

What they say	**What they REALLY mean**
"Oooh, could I just squeeze past you?"	1. _____
"Sounds fun, I'll let you know."	2. _____

Task 3.2 : Answer the questions.

1. What percentage of British people try to avoid arguments?

   _____

2. How many "polite-isms" do Britons use per day on average?

   _____

3. According to the text, what cultural value is behind this behavior? Why do they do it?

Task 4**:** Role-Play "Cultural Translator"

Work in groups. You are a "Cultural Translator" helping foreigners understand the UK. Look at these direct situations. How would a British person say these things politely? How would a person from YOUR country say them?

Situation 1: You think the food your host cooked is terrible.

- British version: "_____"
- Our country version: "_____"

Situation 2: You want a colleague to stop talking so you can work.

- British version: "_____"
- Our country version: "_____"

Situation 3: You don't want to go to your friend's party.

- British version: "_____"
- Our country version: "_____"

Task 5**: Dialogue of Cultures (Discussion)**

Discuss in pairs or small groups:

1. Is it better to be direct (like in our culture) or indirect (like in the UK)?
2. What are the pros and cons of both communication styles?

HOMEWORK

Write a short guide (100 words) for a foreigner coming to your country. Explain 3 phrases or behaviors that mean something different in your culture.
